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Trailer

Intro

As technological advancements in our modern society continue to expand,

the topic of surveillance has become more frequent, which has caused important and complex ethical questions to be raised regarding privacy, safety, the limits of scientific experimentation and individual autonomy.

Many governments and organizations around the world often rationalize the use of serial surveillance by declaring

- used for promoting safety
- efficiency
- for the greater good of the general public welfare

Background

The novel observes after Thomas, a teenaged boy who is awakened in an unknown environment, known as the Glade, with no recollection of his past memories or life. Alongside dozens of other boys, who also have lost their past memories, they all must persevere to survive within this grand perplexing maze.

They are forced to navigate amongst unavoidable dangerous conditions while their behaviors, decisions, and survival strategies are secretly observed as part of collecting data for a larger experiment meant to help the human race survive a global pandemic, called the Flare Virus, which was a biological man-made virus, as they are regularly being monitored by an association known as WICKED.

Utilitarianism in the Maze Runner

Utilitarianism in the Maze Runner

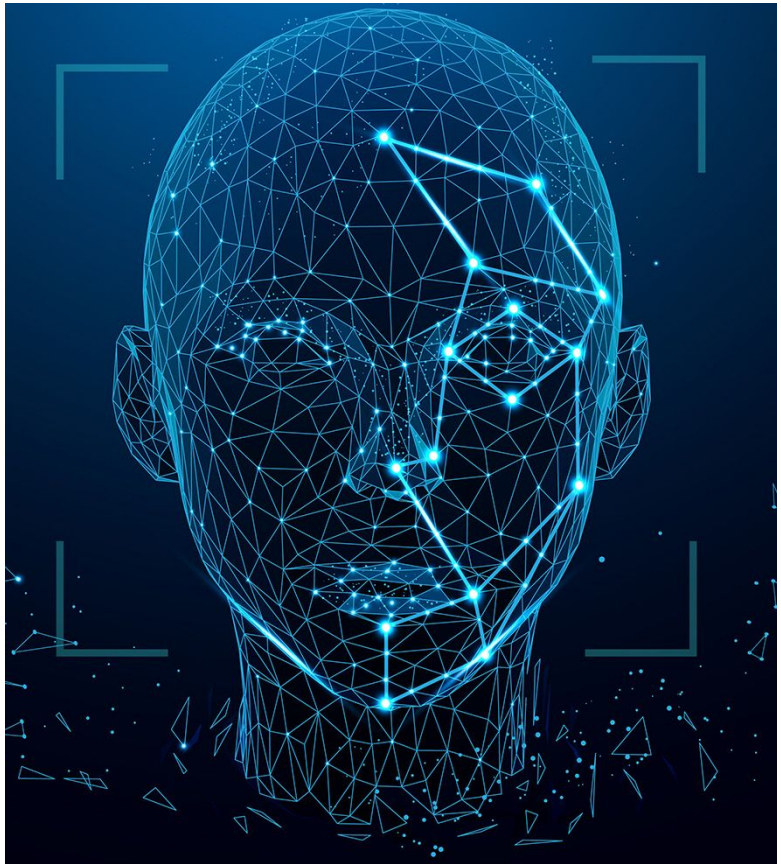
WICKED

WORLD IN CATASTOPHE KILLZONE EXPERIMENT DEPARTMENT

Is WICKD justified?

Utilitarianism in the Maze Runner

Utilitarianism in Society



- Reads personal info
  - Emails
  - Texts
  - Pictures
- Surveillance cameras
  - Facial recognition
- Collects data
  - Train AI
  - Predictive analytics
  - Tracks behavior to personalize
- Location sharing
  - Instagram/Meta added new feature in update where your location can be seen by others (without permission)

Surveillance Justified?

- Utilitarianism: ends justify means
- Surveillance cameras
  - Reasons:
    - Catch criminal activity, collect evidence, monitor c
      - Safety
- Maze Runner surveillance:
  - Collect data, monitor the children, analyze brain activity under stress
  - Track location, responses
  - Justified to find a cure
  - Sacrifice a small group for the benefit of all

When is the line crossed?

- Utilitarianism focuses on greatest happiness for all, even if it means small losses overall or suffering for a small group
- Focus on outcomes rather than intent
- Surveillance
  - Outcome: catches suspects, reads texts to catch extreme cases
  - Consequence: privacy given up, personal info read without consent
- If outcome is good, that is all that matters
- In terms of utilitarianism, it becomes bad if the outcome is bad
  - WCKD: moral only if they do end up finding a cure
  - Immoral if the situation gets worse even after their experiments on children

Kant Ethics: Surveillance

- Children are constantly monitored and manipulated by WICKED
- The maze is designed as a controlled experiment
- “Everything you lived through was calculated… Catalyst to study your reactions, your brainwaves, your thoughts.”
- The children are treated as a means to achieve a cure, not ends in themselves.

Kant Ethics: Loss of Autonomy

- WICKED erases the children’s memories before the experiment
- They cannot understand their situation or give consent
- This prevents rational decision making
- Kantian ethics requires respect for rational autonomy

Mass Surveillance in Society and Kantianism

- License-plate-recognition technology becoming even more powerful with AI
- Cameras capture vast amounts of information beyond license plates
  - Lawn signs, flags outside people's homes, bumper stickers, people wearing T-shirts with text
- Information shared with police, database accessible to authorized people
  - Can be used to target people with specific political beliefs
- Kantianism would not approve of this mass surveillance
  - Sees individuals as a means to a specific end (safety) and not as an end themselves
  - Eliminates people's autonomy
    - Supposed to act according to own will, but surveillance could impede that
  - May not be universalizable
    - As everyone is being surveilled, could be hard to justify surveilling even those that have had no previous run-ins with the law

Conclusion

"We can't lose our humanity, no matter the end result."

- The Right Arm, The Maze Runner

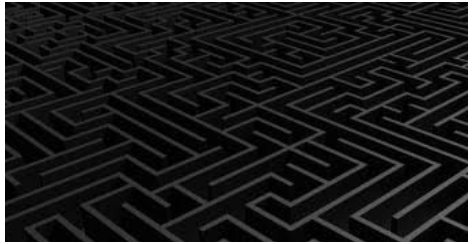
Utilitarianism	Kantianism
Greatest good for the greatest number: does suffering justify a cure?	Treat individuals as ends, not means: autonomy and dignity above all.

Both frameworks reveal the moral dangers of unchecked surveillance.

Reflection / Synthesis ideas:

- Despite approaching ethics from completely different angles, both utilitarianism AND kantianism reach the same verdict on WICKED- that's a powerful conclusion in itself
- The fact that WICKED's motto is literally "WICKED is good" shows how dangerous it is when organizations get to define their own morality without outside accountability
- Neither ethical framework is perfect on its own- utilitarianism is too easily weaponized to justify harm, kantianism can feel rigid when lives are genuinely at stake- but together they give a fuller picture
- The children in the Maze never got to weigh in on whether the experiment was worth it- the absence of their voice is itself a moral failure that both theories highlight

Broader implications / closing thoughts:



- The Maze Runner asks us who gets to decide what the "greater good" actually is- and who bears the cost of that decision
- WICKED believed it was acting morally, which is arguably more disturbing than if it knew it was doing wrong- good intentions don't make unethical actions ethical
- The real cautionary tale isn't just about surveillance- it's about what happens when power goes unchecked and people in charge stop seeing individuals as human
- Dashner wrote this as fiction, but the ethical dilemmas he raises have no fictional answers- they demand real ones

A cautionary tale

WICKED → AI Surveillance

Beetle blades mirror today's facial recognition, license plate readers, and behavioral tracking AI.

"Greater Good" Logic

Governments and corporations use the same utilitarian justification as WICKED — rarely with accountability.

Who Consents?

Both Kantian ethics and The Maze Runner force the same question: who controls surveillance, and who agreed to it?

The Real Question

As AI grows more powerful, the ethical frameworks in this novel are no longer fiction — they are urgent.